

Vocabulary & Grammar for the Agile Memo

CMG-ANG4 — Working as a team · Language toolkit

1. Modals — describing roles and recommendations

Modal	Use	Example
must / have to	obligation, a strict rule of the role	The Scrum Master must facilitate every sprint planning.
should	recommendation, best practice	The team should keep the Daily Stand-up under 15 minutes.
can / can't	ability or permission	Any team member can raise a blocker during the stand-up.
may / might	possibility	Priorities might change before the next sprint.
will need to	a future obligation caused by the change	Developers will need to estimate their own tasks from now on.

For the memo: use modals when you define each role — "The Product Owner **must** prioritize the backlog," "Developers **should** update the board daily."

2. Will vs. going to — announcing changes

	Will	Going to
Use	Decisions made at the moment of speaking; predictions without present evidence; promises	Plans already decided before speaking; predictions based on present evidence
Memo example	"I will answer any questions during the stand-up."	"We are going to switch to two-week sprints starting Monday."

Since a memo announces a *decision already made*, "going to" often fits better for the main announcement ("We are going to adopt Scrum"), while "will" fits better for promises and spontaneous offers ("I will be available to answer questions").

3. Conditionals — discussing consequences

Type	Form	Use	Example
Zero	If + present, present	General truths about how Scrum works	If a task is blocked, the team raises it at the stand-up.
First	If + present, will + base verb	Realistic future consequences	If we adopt Scrum, stakeholders will see progress every two weeks.
Second	If + past, would + base verb	Hypothetical / unlikely situations	If we stayed with Waterfall, feedback would arrive too late.
Third	If + past perfect, would have + past participle	Past hypothetical (what didn't happen)	If we had adopted Agile last year, we would have avoided that delay.

4. Core Agile & IT vocabulary

- **backlog** — prioritized to-do list
 - **sprint** — short, fixed work cycle
 - **stand-up** — short daily sync meeting
 - **retrospective** — team review of the process
 - **stakeholder** — anyone with an interest in the project's outcome
- **deliverable** — a concrete result handed over to the client
 - **milestone** — a key checkpoint in the project timeline
 - **scope** — the boundaries of what the project will (and won't) include
 - **iterative** — repeated in cycles, each one improving on the last
 - **self-organizing** — a team that decides internally how to divide work

5. Decision-making & persuasion phrases

Function	Useful phrases
Giving an opinion	"In my view..." · "I would argue that..." · "It seems to me that..."
Being in favour	"I am in favour of..." · "I would recommend..."
Acknowledging concerns	"I understand that this may seem..." · "It's a fair point that..."

Persuading	"However, the benefit is..." · "This will allow us to..."
Concluding / calling to action	"Moving forward, I would like you to..." · "Let's make sure that..."

6. Quick self-test

Fill the gap with will / going to, then check the logic against the rules above.

1. We have already decided: the team _____ use Trello starting next sprint.
2. Don't worry about the board — I _____ set it up for you this afternoon.
3. If stakeholders like the pilot sprint, we _____ extend Scrum to the other projects.

Answers: 1. are going to (decided in advance) · 2. will (spontaneous offer) · 3. will (first conditional consequence)